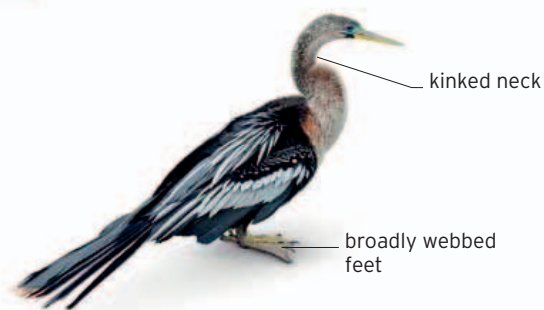




Anhinga

Anhinga anhinga

Found commonly in swamps and waterways, the anhinga is the Americas' equivalent of the similar African darter. It roosts on trees and mangroves, but leaves to feed soon after sunrise, flying to open water. It swims low in the water, head and neck raised, earning the alternative name "snakebird."

Spearfishing

With unusually dense bones and plumage that quickly absorbs water, the anhinga sinks easily and swims underwater for up to a minute. It does not have the powerful legs of the cormorants for active pursuit, but feeds more like an underwater heron, waiting for

a chance to spear a passing fish. Special vertebrae and neck musculature give its neck a permanent kink, and an instant, rapid forward stab. The anhinga then rises to the surface, shakes the fish free, and swallows it.

Anhingas nest in mixed colonies with other tree-nesting birds. The female builds the nest from twigs and reeds collected by the male. Up to six eggs are incubated for three to four weeks. The chicks are fed at first with pre-digested fish from the parents' throats and then whole fish. They leave the nest after six weeks, but remain dependent on their parents for a few more weeks.



▽ OUTSTRETCHED WINGS

Anhingas display with one or both wings outstretched. They also regularly perch with open wings to help dry saturated feathers and to regulate their body temperature.

